focus on the Indus Delta, Sindh, Baluchistan and Sistan. As a young man, Pottinger had himself travelled through Persia and Sindh disguised as a Muslim merchant and, knowing the territory as well as any other Company servant, grew to be every bit as territorial as Wade.

In between dutifully playing his part at Shah Shuja's phantom court, Wade spent his days piecing together a jigsaw of news and gossip through his growing list of informants: Indian clerks, traders, passing mercenaries and sympathetic noblemen were all recruited to provide news and bazaar *gup-shup* [gossip]. Perhaps his most useful correspondent was a remarkable British deserter, originally known as James Lewis, who had fled the Company's service and set himself up in Kabul under the assumed name of Charles Masson.

Masson was a keenly inquisitive Londoner who, after deserting his regiment and faking his own death during the siege of Bharatpur in 1826, had walked through north India, crossed the Indus and explored Afghanistan on foot, living like a wandering dervish. Armed with a copy of Arrian's *Life of Alexander the Great*, he became the first westerner to explore Afghanistan's archaeology. Following in Alexander's footsteps, he located the remains of the great Bactrian Greek city of Bagram in the Shomali Plain, while elsewhere he methodically excavated Buddhist stupas and Kushan palaces, dutifully sending the pick of his finds down to the new Asiatic Society in Calcutta. Somehow Wade learned the secret of Masson's real identity as a deserter, and before long had blackmailed him into becoming an 'intelligencer', dangling both the threat of capital punishment and the lure of a royal pardon in front of him, and so ensuring a stream of regular and accurate reports from Afghanistan for the first time.

This growing intelligence network was developed at a time of rapidly changing geopolitics. The Napoleonic threat was now over. Instead by the 1820s it was Russia that kept the Company's hawks fretting over their glasses of madeira.

Since seeing off Napoleon in 1812, the Russians had moved their frontier south and eastwards almost as fast as Wellesley had moved that of the Company north and westwards, and it was becoming increasingly evident –